

apoapsis

space and silence

by Shen Ge

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Dedications

Most people put down one name. I find it in my heart to be unable to be so restrained. Since I love lists, here is an incomplete list of just a few people in my life that I give thanks to who has helped me grow and become a better person. This book would not be possible without just at least mentioning their names, whether they know it or not.

- Goddess/God for all that She/He created in this beautiful world
- My mom for biologically producing me and her love of literature which by nurture got passed on to me.
- My therapists past and present who were guides on my path towards healing from past traumas and self-understanding.
- Alicia B. who I consider my big sister for always been there for me in both career and emotional support.

- Justin Y. who gave me hope in the future of non-conformist Chinese Americans with near-infinite optimism.
- Megan F. who gave me such love and opened my eyes to what could be possible in literature, artistic expression, and love.
- Richard who considered me his adopted son.
- DJ who understands me on space, science fiction, and life.
- Joe H. who I consider a grandfatherly figure and have offered me continuous emotional support.
- Brett M. who gave me financial advice and emotional support.
- John G. who I work with and pray with.
- Sam W. who I can talk about trajectories in space and emotions.
- Sarah M. who inspires me with both her operational knowledge and her artistic skills.
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- Michelle F. who inspires me with her courage in tackling the challenges of her own life and her spirit in helping mine.
- All others who I have yet to mention but know who they are and the outsized roles they have played in my life.

Foreword

Writing the foreword of any work is daunting and no doubt even more so when it comes to completely revamping the prior work. Yes, unabashedly, I can state that this is the second draft of what was previously going to be a different type of work.

The characters depicted may or may not be modeled on real humans the author knows but are meant to be separate fictional characters. These characters include the following.

Position	Universe A	Universe B	Universe C
Captain	Robert Sanders	Robert Sanders	Stefan Calzón
Chief Officer	Vishwathmane	Vishwathmane	Shen
Chief Scientist	Lorie Roberts	Lorie Roberts	Dennis Roberts
Comms Officer	Maria Sandivar	Mary Sands	Mary Sands
Navigator	Kara Smith	Kara Smith	Kara Smith
Navigator	Joel Jones	Roy Jones	Richard Jones
Ethnographer	Megan	N/A	N/A

FOREWORD

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Chapter 1: The Journal

A lone man sat at his metal desk basked under the dim glow of a desk lamp. The window outside was pitch black though he thought he could see at least a few notable stars. Perhaps that red dot at the far edge was Mars. The sun was on the opposite side of the spacecraft which he accepted as an unbidden celestial gift. Thoughts seemed to come easier in darkness. He picked up a yellow legal pad and started to write. Words formed.

*Simple words are enough to describe this feeling. Is it emptiness? Excitement? Melancholy? Melancholy and emptiness are similar in nature. A **particular type of ennui**. Cousins almost or rather a parent-child relationship. One begets another. A subclass maybe if you're into object-oriented programming.*

*The window outside showed only darkness. A void deeper than what most of humanity has seen. But is it deeper than the void I felt within? I felt that there was nothing more for me to do back on Earth. Parents deceased. Relatives alive are those I barely know more than the barista at the local Starbucks. Divorced. Not talking to ex-wife except for the kids. Kids **grown** up now. Never did **connect** well with them either. May be generational gap. Maybe he's just a **maverick** too obsessed with his own inner thoughts and hobbies and interests and travels to really connect with anyone on their level.*

What do I know? There's a great deal of communication that passes as "normal" social interaction which bores me. I was always the odd

one out even if I was the most popular in some ways – a gala dinner in my honor for instance. I said my inspiring words and then spent the next few hours in insipid vapid conversations. Everyone saw just images of me that they thought they knew. When I tried to speak my true thoughts to family, they just thought of me as an alien.

***Might as well be one right? In my entire life, I have yet to meet someone who I felt truly** understands me**. Maybe that's why I signed up for this voyage. Volunteered. Applied. To see possible real aliens or at least the remnants of their technology.*

*Humans are draining social creatures. The solution I found was to spend **less and less** time with all of them. The government must be surprised that it didn't need to try very hard to convince me to go on this one-way trip. I knew even before they told me. There's not enough fuel to get there and back.*

***How many others on this ship knows** this? We have a crew of a dozen people. At least some of them must be smart enough to know this. Maybe they just don't care. Back in the day, people were duped by an organization claiming to raise money for a one-way trip to Mars. Millions signed up then. **Finding a dozen people who don't care to live beyond the mission isn't difficult. *

*Why do these kids do this? I doubt they're wanting to leave an empty Earth; they're somehow drawn to the empty void of space more than the abundance of Earth. A true mystery there. They must have families, significant others, friends and interests outside that of space exploration. Yet, they're choosing to throw it all away for this. Is uncovering the greatest mystery yet discovered in humanity's short history **really worth** throwing your entire life away?*

So, they're the optimists and I'm the pessimist but we're all somehow in the same boat. Or rather, the same ship. The same damn spaceship. Completely different spectrums of seeing what Earth has to offer but all wanting to leave it. Isn't that a damn irony?

He stopped writing as his eye caught a plastic facsimile of a glass

bottle of Topo Chico strapped to the corner of his desk. It wasn't a real glass bottle; they would never allow glass in beverage containers on a spacecraft. That was his favorite sparkling water. When he was feeling melancholy, it also tends to carry his mind to the blackened edges of a memory from a decade ago.

He was freshly divorced then and was living in a one-bedroom luxury apartment by himself. There was a balcony on the ground floor with a fountain laid in front of him. It was a private courtyard shared by the residents of the complex which lived on the inner side of the apartment building. He enjoyed sitting out there just watching the fountain and letting his mind wander while he drank his Topo Chico slowly. After the chaos of the marriage and the divorce process, he relished this calm. That day with its drizzling gray sky with light rain resonated with his mood – peaceful sadness.

A man with a dog walked into the courtyard. They wandered around a bit while the dog peed quietly in a corner on some fake grass. Presumably, the man was a neighbor who was just letting his dog out. This man probably had no intention of disturbing his peace. Yet, that mundane activity by another human being and another creature disturbed his peace immensely. He felt that he did not want to see another human being.

He had quickly finished his Topo Chico and went inside to lay in bed staring at the ceiling daydreaming of having true peace.

In the present, he put his pen on paper again.

*Everyone here had to go through a month of solitary confinement in a small self-sustaining 10 x 10 x **10 meter** cube to be considered even viable as a candidate. **Out of the battery of tests administered to candidates, this was the one where one was most likely to weed out the ones who didn't want to go. About 80% didn't pass it. Some went crazy and begged to be released earlier and some **removed their own applications afterwards though they technically passed.***

Human society as a whole has declined overall to know and appreciate what it is like to be truly alone. Technology has permeated itself everywhere in the form of instant communication and information. In the days before the phone, social media, augmented reality and virtual worlds, one could sit quietly next to a fire and do nothing in the stillness of one's mind. Nowadays, that is a far removed reality where satellite signals are able to** reach even the most remote jungle or desert.

He paused as he recalled a time in his youth as part of a group tour taking an expedition to the Sahara Desert. One of the last vestiges of what truly remains remote in this world. It was considered one of the most remote parts remaining in the world. While he was fascinated by the sand dunes and the clear night sky, his peers were too busy recording their adventures and posting them online to even truly be present.

He thought it ironic that now that precisely because of all the noise that people have generated, we have caught the attention of a extraterrestrial intelligence. Here was a signal from an unknown source tapping humanity on the shoulder indubitably after watching countless hours of humanity's self-generated social content from the information bubble that has been propagating outwards from the solar system for the last two centuries.

He wondered if this was happening to him right now. He had addressed the crew earlier and then informed them that he was going to rest in his cabin. With no urgent tasks at hand and being the captain, no one gainsaid his right for some privacy. Maybe he was a misanthrope to some degree. He frequently felt tired from seeing and interacting with people.

A loud beep erupted from the intercom on his desk which completely interrupted his thoughts. This was an indication that he was needed in the control room. He sighed. The time of the end for self-musing always seemed to come without warning. Responsibility and appearances are necessary. In slow methodical steps, he grasped the cap-

tain's uniform strapped to his bed and carefully undid the straps. With one practiced motion, he donned it before it floated away.

There was a noticeable sense of unease he saw in the faces of several crewmembers that he passed by as he swam towards the control room. When he crossed over the threshold into the relatively large spherical room, everyone looked at him and gave him a salute. This was not a military vessel, but some traditions tend to follow along.

The six console controllers were already seated in front of their respective consoles. His second-in-command, a dark-haired Indian-American man with a name he has yet to fully able pronounce, stated, "Captain on the deck!"

He gave a nod and then drifted over to his seat in the center of the room. With practiced ease, he pulled himself on to the chair and strapped himself down in the seatbelts. Then he looked around and calmly asked, "What's the situation?"

His second-in-command stated. "We are within range of communicating with the anomaly."

"Vishwathmane, let's call it Nexus 1 like protocol indicates. I understand that we're all on first name basis here and like to keep things formal but since official exchanges are logged, we should stick with that formality at the very least."

"Yes, captain. Nexus 1 is within our broadcasting range. Should we attempt contact?"

He nodded. "Initiate contact."

The silence in the air lingered for far longer than anticipated. The screen on the communication screen showed no more blips indicating no signal. After a half minute of silence, a young woman with light brown hair sitting at the operations console with a sign that said COMMS spoke into her headset: "We have LOS."

"Comms, how is this possible? Loss of signal isn't expected for another three hours." The questioning voice came from an older gentle-

man with a scruffy beard and bleary eyes.

The comms operator calmly replied. “Captain, that would be the case if the comms relay satellite was working properly. Since it malfunctioned last week probably due to the incidence of that solar flare, we’ve had to send the signal direct from our antenna here.”

“We’re using a high gain narrow beam antenna, no?” questioned the captain.

“Yes, we are. I suspect we have a navigation error in identifying where the spacecraft is, and our pointing might be inaccurate.”

“How much can Nexus 1 possibly deviate? It’s in a heliocentric elliptical orbit around the sun easily predictable in the short term by just an inverse square law approximation for the force. We had signal about an hour ago. There’s no conceivable way that the trajectory deviated that much from nominal in that short of an epoch span. Besides, we’re using the latest software that has all the gravitational forces of the outer planets and the moons considered. I don’t think you should blame Navigation. If anything, you should check your Comms system again. Maybe you misconfigured the radio.”

These snarky replies came from a middle-aged pudgy man with greasy hair sitting behind a console that read Navigation. He looked smugly at the Comms personnel in disbelief. She shook her head. “No, I checked the system several times. Everything is configured nominally on our end. Either the comms system on the spacecraft is not operational in which case there’ll be nothing we can do at all, or something perturbed its trajectory.”

“Maybe there was a momentum dump?” the captain asked. He continued answering his own question. “No, that’s not scheduled for another half-year. Besides, that little perturbation shouldn’t change the trajectory this much in just an hour.”

There was a sudden jump in the display. Startled, the woman working Comms quickly called out. “Captain, I am detecting a signal!”

“Comms, increase the gain,” the captain nodded.

“Just imagine, this is the first time an extraterrestrial civilization is hailing our spacecraft. I wonder what kind of message they will send!” these excited words hailed from a middle-aged woman behind a console that shone in bold letters SCIENCE.

“Chief Scientist Roberts, try to keep it professional here. Comms, what do you see?”

“One moment, Captain. The signal is not yet stable. The antenna is not performing as well as the nominal configuration.”

“I thought that was replaced last week with the emergency EVA last week after the SPE?”

“Well, the antenna is fine but it was always meant to be a backup and hence the receiver gain is only about half the power as the original.”

“I thought Avionics said we can use the other radio to strengthen the signal?”

“Avionics has assigned the task to someone, but the lab is understaffed and the someone is working on other high priority items first.”

“What could possibly be more important than our capability to communicate with the unknown spacecraft?”

“With all due respect, Captain, we are still trying to get back the DTE link. We have basic telemetry but no capacity to send any high-rate data back to Earth.”

The captain grimaced with annoyance. “If we need to allocate more human resources to get all our comm systems back up and running, we can do that after this. With only four technicians, maybe you can go back there yourself and assist.”

“With all due respect, I am not sure how much help I can be. The technicians know what they are doing. I will just be getting in their way.”

“Sitting on the bridge doesn’t mean that’s the only role you will be asked to play. Dr. Sandivar, as someone who graduated from MIT and worked in the space industry for over two decades, you’re telling me you know less than these technicians who went to community college.”

Everyone within earshot tensed up at the overtly condescending attitude displayed by the captain. He had also somehow put a sarcastic tinge on the Comms officer’s name. *Just because you went to school and worked doesn’t mean I should know everything.* she thought.

Before she could respond in a more graceful manner than her thoughts, she was saved by a comment from a young man sitting for Ground Network. “Captain, we’re receiving an audiovisual signal.”

The captain turned to him. “Any chance of a virus infecting our system?”

He shook his head. “Negative, this is receive-only with no write capability.”

“In that case, Comms, put it on the big screen.”

There was a moment as Comms typed a few things on the console and clicked on a button. Three large monitors in the middle of the room now all displayed the same scene. There was the sound of static and speckled white noise. The captain grabbed a remote and turned up the volume. Coincidentally while he was doing so, the screen cleared and a scene was laid out in front of them in high-definition video. An androgynous voice started speaking describing the scene.

Dr. Sandivar spoke aloud what was in everyone’s minds, “This shouldn’t be possible with our data rate and latency...”

“Quiet, this is something to be investigated later. Please record as much as you can. Let’s see what they’re wanting to say,” the captain said.

Dr. Sandivar nodded and punched a few keys on his console to start the recording. Everyone in the room stared raptly at what was un-

folding in front of them. The voice indistinguishably male and female started with the words “Reproducing the past requires a sizzle in the air...”

Chapter 2: The Break

*Reproducing the past requires a sizzle in the air. The air was crisp and a gentle breeze carried the faint scent of sand and sagebrush as two people laid side by side on a blanket. There were two nondescript knapsacks of a dull brown color next to each of them. To an unenlightened 21st century human, one looked like a prepubescent girl around the age of 8 and the other looked like a young boy freshly out of his teens. The same unenlightened individual would also assume that they were siblings given their remarkable facial resemblance and the fact that they looked to be East Asian. Perhaps these two were out camping in the desert enjoying the night sky away from the light pollution of metropolitan areas? Perhaps the knapsacks held their sleeping bags and the tent that they have yet to pitch up? The unenlightened 21st century **human** would be wrong on every front but for the sake of placing labels on characters, let us address them as brother and sister for now.*

The blanket looked much too thin to provide much comfort on the rocky ground filled with pebbles and small vegetation. Inscribed on the top right corner of the blanket in tiny script were imprinted the alphanumeric sequence CJ2127. Neither of them showed any discomfort. The two gazed at the starlit sky in silence until the presumed girl broke it with a question.

“Can you read me some poetry?”

*The **boy smiled and picked up** a book that was **previously hidden***

under **the** blanket. “**Sure**, the poetry section of this story will **start on page 99.**”

“Does that one **include** the **one about the eclipse?**”

“No, that would be in the dream of the eclipse described in chapter 3. There are three different versions** documented** and one of them has the **poem.**”

“That’s okay. You can read me that one later.”

*The boy started reading. “Let’s start with the **one called Milky Way.** The Milky Way is **fun-sized** as the candy bar says**...”*

*The boy continued reading for **another** ten minutes before the girl yawned and **said.** “That’s enough for now. More can come later. **You don’t want to bore the audience.”*

*In an eerily creepy fashion, both stood up and turned towards the camera** as if addressing the crew. “I hope none of you are bored by our literary forays. I promise you this will be a good story with every **video** you receive.”*

The screen then cut off into blankness and the narration voice stopped as well. For a moment, everyone was stunned in confused silence and then immediately all started talking. The captain raised a hand and they all quieted. “One at a time if you have anything to say.”

“What the hell was that?” the navigator Kara immediately blurted.

“I don’t know. Do we have all the video recorded?” the captain asked.

“Yes,” Dr. Sandivar replied. “It was difficult but we managed to download it all while it was transmitting but how such a clear signal could be sent with such a low data rate is unclear to me.”

“This is a real headscratcher but I trust that the expertise of those onboard can figure this out given time. For now, let’s make sure we

can safely get this data into the appropriate hands. Does anyone have an immediate idea of what we just saw?"

Vishwathmane shook his head. "Captain, I'm still trying to compose my thoughts. The poetry wasn't terrible but it wasn't the quality level that my English professor would have considered world-class."

The navigator snorted. "And how would you know how to rate poetry?"

Vishwathmane stiffened and gave a man a glare. "Officer Jones, I would have you know that I double majored in both electrical engineering as well as classic literature."

"A rare specimen indeed for such a motley crew," the chief scientist remarked and a few people chuckled.

The captain cleared his throat. "Dr. Roberts, please quiet down. All of you are acting like a group of school children instead of supposedly what the best humanity have to offer."

Turning back to the Chief Officer, he said, "Is that all?"

"Well, I was trying to assess the origins of the accents provided by the two children as well as their ethnic appearance, but that part is a complete mystery. The pronunciation indicates no particular country of origin. Perhaps our ethnographer would know but since we have no recording there's not much we can do to get her perspective."

The captain nodded. "Vishwathmane, after this meeting, find our ethnographer and give her this data to look into. For the rest of us, we still need to navigate this ship and send this transmission to Earth for our experts there to dissect as well. Comms, please prepare to compress and send this entire video to the next available ground station."

"Uh, the next one wouldn't be for another three hours. Orbital geometry is a bitch and the Earth won't rotate any faster. Of course, it'll probably take me a few hours to compress and save the data in the right format."

“Then get started on that. We don’t have time to waste.”

He snapped his finger and everyone got to work.

Chapter 3: The Dream

Navigator Kara had a dream that night about a solar eclipse. It was like something she saw when she was a little girl of about 8 but surprisingly different than the experience she recounted. It felt like several different memories of others pieced together and she was experiencing them all at once. When she awoke, before the dream scattered into nothingness, she grabbed her voice recorder beside her bed and started narrating.

STARTING RECORDING:

I was lying outside under the shade of a tree on a sunny day reading from the book **Einstein and the Total Eclipse** by Peter Coles in the chapter on the Anatomy of an Eclipse. I heard myself read these words:

“But the possibility of having a total eclipse relies on one extraordinary and fascinating coincidence. The Moon is much closer to us than the Sun is (250,000 miles compared to 93 million), but is also very much smaller (its diameter is just over 2000 miles, while the sun is about 900,000 miles across). Somehow these numbers have conspired with the laws of trigonometry to produce a situation in which the apparent size of the Moon’s disk is almost exactly the same as that of the Sun. There is no convincing explanation of how this remarkable coincidence came about, but without it total eclipses would be impossible.”

I paused and took out a pen. I found a blank page on a notepad and

drew a diagram on there to do some basic calculations to confirm what the author stated. I know the moon is approximately 1080 miles in radius and the sun is approximately 433,000 miles in radius so I will use those values instead of the book-given one.

Calculations indicate angular radius of moon to be 0.25 degrees and that of sun to be 0.27 degrees. However, since the distance to the moon and sun both varies since the orbit is elliptical and not perfectly circular, there are epoch intervals when both of those coincide with each other.

This was simple enough math but sometimes it feels good to prove things by paper and pencil instead of just trusting what is written on paper.

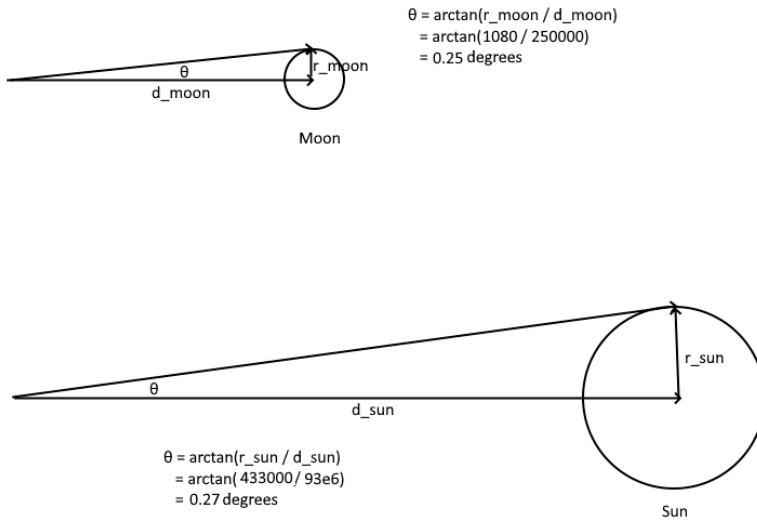


Figure 1: Eclipse picture drawn

The air suddenly grew cooler. Is there a storm coming? I looked up and saw that the sun was slowly being occluded by a shadowy object would could only be the moon. “Strange! I didn’t think there was

a solar eclipse predicted for today. It's not even the new moon and eclipses can only happen during the new moon."

An unbidden voice came to her mind and instinctively she knew these were the words written by Annie Dillard on the impossibility of capturing a sight via a photograph. *The lenses of telescopes and cameras can no **more** cover the breadth and scale of the visual array than language can cover the breadth and simultaneity of internal experience. Lenses enlarge the sight, omit its context, and make of it a pretty and sensible picture, like something on a Christmas card.*

Who was Annie Dillard? I think she's an American author who wrote a lot about nature poetically with frequent references to science. I'm not known to remember quotes by anyone so being able to recite this from memory felt strange.

What was equally peculiar is to see everything in the crystal light of sudden twilight converging towards darkness. There's also a feeling of impending doom. The eclipse should only last a few minutes and then it would be over but that wasn't the feeling I felt then. I felt it would come and then last forever. This would have contradicted every aspect of celestial mechanics but that feeling resided there. The moon cannot stop its motion or else it would quickly collide with Earth due to gravity. It was in perpetual free fall. The only way would be for the moon to stay exactly where it is while blocking the sun would be for it to also counteract gravity exactly by accelerating in a direction radially outwards.

These thoughts, useless as they might be, were going through my brain while observing this phenomenon. I recalled years ago at a tender age of 8 seeing the 2024 solar eclipse in Dallas, TX. That was the pivotal moment then which led me to want to learn more about celestial motion. All that led me down the path of studying physics and then later aerospace.

But what does all this have to do with now? Simply that the eclipse was not disappearing. It seemed to persist. A sudden bell-like gong

rang in my mind. It reverberated. Then, a calm feminine voice akin to one from a meditation video or a yoga teacher resonated in my mind.

*There is no life without change. Read A Day Curated in the Poetry section of the book **you are part of**.*

The words made no sense to me. The sky was still half-black in that eclipse twilight. “What does that mean?”

The voice only repeated itself again with the same words.

“This is not helping. What book is this and what do you mean I’m part of a book?”

Once again, there was no change in the words that continued to be spoken in my mind. Just as I was about to feel like I was slowly going insane, the voice stopped. At the same time, time seemed to have started again. I could see a tiny sliver of the sun poking through the previously completely covered up circle. The moon was moving again.

A whisper began very close to my ears. “Dynamic balance is essential to the way of the unity of opposites.”

It was a different voice than before. This was not spoken calmly but in a sense of desperate urgency. Startled, I looked around but saw no one in my vicinity. More whispers started from an ever-growing number of invisible entities. Some seemed to be right next to my ears while others seemed to be inside my skull.

The voices repeated abstract notions. “The unity is a process which now lets in the dark and now the light. Like the orbit of a planet around a star, there is periapsis and there is apoapsis. There is distance and there is nearness. Everything changes in the system but the system itself does not change.”

“Who are you? What do you want?” I yelled.

There was no acknowledgement. The voices only continued. “Con-

sider even the motion of a simple ball moving clockwise around a circle with constant speed. Project its motion into a 1D plane as if capturing a shadow. In the projection, it slows down as it reaches the edge, turns around and accelerates again only to slow down once more – and so the endless cycle continues. An oscillation between two opposite points. Is this evident to you?”

Hoping the voice would stop, I said. “Give me a moment and let me do the math. For simplicity, I’ll consider the initial condition at $t=0$ to be at $(r,0)$.”

I flipped to the next page of my notepad and wrote down the Cartesian coordinates describing uniform circular motion. Then, I looked at the y-component of it and took the derivative.

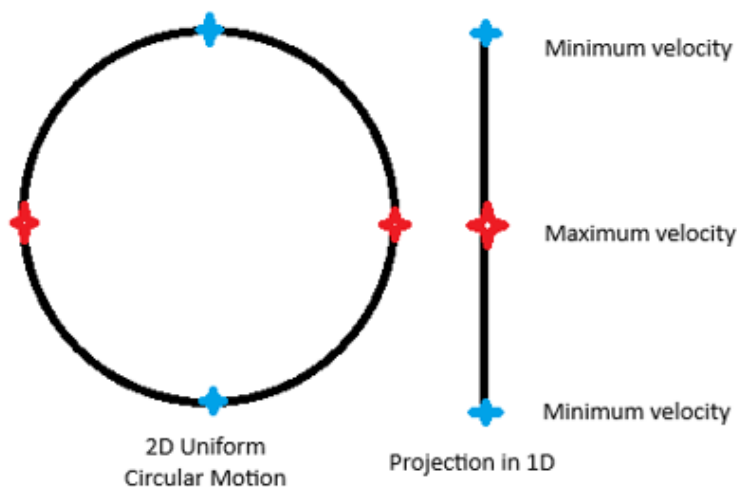


Figure 2: Circular 2D shadow drawn

$$y = -r \cos t$$

$$\omega = 2\pi / T \text{ where } T \text{ is the period}$$

where the Greek letter omega is the angular velocity defined as radians per second, t is the time in seconds and r is the radius of the

circle.

I narrated as I described the results, “In this equation, $y\text{-dot}$ (the y -component of the velocity which is also the shadow velocity) is 0 when t is a quarter of the period or three quarters of the period. It is maximum when t is equal to 0 or half of the period. Translated into position space, this means that the shadow moves fastest when the ball is at $(+r, 0)$ or $(-r, 0)$ and it moves slowest when the ball is at $(0, -r)$ and $(0, +r)$.”

“You can do the math but do you realize the deeper meaning with this analogy?”

I felt that I knew the answer but I was not 100% certain. I replied. “I can guess but why don’t you tell me?”

There as a brief pause before the voice continued. “Polarities that exists in lower dimensions do not exist in higher dimensions. The extremity of the velocity observed in 1D is but uniformity from a 2D perspective.”

I nodded. This is still insane but at least a conversation was happening. “You mean to say that we cannot understand why opposites consistently occur in our world but this is because we lack an understanding from our limited perspective. This is one of the oldest concepts in human philosophy and religion. The nature of duality and the concept of change. What does this have to do with me?”

Chapter 4: The Cantina

Sometimes, life can take you to the oddest of places, thought Megan. If twelve summers ago, someone had told her that she would be on a spacecraft flying towards the first confirmed extraterrestrial vessel, she would have construed it as pure nonsense. This isn't because she didn't believe in the existence of aliens but rather because she didn't believe she had any skills that would warrant her a position on a ship.

She took a sip from her flask of whiskey as she took out her journal to write. She was glad that she was able to find a quiet corner of what the crew affectionately called the cantina. Due to the efficiency of space requirements, it served as a meal hall as well with about half a dozen round tables. Not many people came here during this time of the sleep cycle which served her just fine. Thoughts flourished better in solitude.

If this was on Earth or on a research station at Phobos, I would be taking a walk first to marinate my thoughts. Seeing that I don't have the luxury of space on this ship, I made do with some walks on the personal treadmill. Sometimes, I feel that I really shouldn't be here or maybe rather it's apt to say that my intention to come here isn't as pure as people may think. I love space but I don't think I would have gathered enough courage to leave if it wasn't because of how stifling I was starting to feel.

My life was becoming stifling and I didn't want to keep drowning in the chaos of human relationships. Love is a word and concept which I thought I knew what it meant from all my reflections and therapy but it has proven time and time again to be difficult to truly offer and receive in a health way.

Am I a coward for choosing to say bon voyage and leave this world? Those who have more patience or faith would try a bit more. Do I give up too easily or am I just unlucky in landing in the same situation time after time? To leave is sometimes the easiest option. Some people would move to another state, country, the moon or Mars. I chose to take it to the next level. I threw a dart in the dark never expecting to actually be picked up by this project.

"And yet, here I am, whereas possibly worthier candidates are residing on Earth. And all because of one book I wrote," she mused aloud to herself as she took another sip from her drink.

"And what a book it was!" a voice continued for her.

Megan jolted with a startle and looked up from her journal. She saw a tall brunette with a broad grin standing in front of her. "Navigator Kara, what are you doing here?"

"No formalities needed. I'm just Kara to you. Another ship mate ready to wind down just like anyone else, I suppose. After that garbled mess, I needed to get a drink. Mind if I sit down?" she gestured to the empty chair in front of her.

Megan shook her head. "Go ahead. I'm not expecting company."

"Well, you're definitely the most pleasant of the bunch. An outsider of a sort I would say."

"You're quite blunt, aren't you?"

"One of my many charming qualities as the captain would point out," Kara said with a sigh. "I don't suppose you worked out the meaning of it all. You did write a book on it."

“The messages from the aliens?” the word alien still sounded strange and foreign to her tongue but she forced it out for lack of a more proper phrase.

Kara nodded. “No one can make sense of it. As the resident ET expert, I thought you might have some idea who went with the hard sciences.”

Megan shook her head. “I’m still working on it. It’s not that simple. There seems to be messages within messages. An enigma wrapped inside another one and possibly another one. Who knows how many layers there are?”

“Not a Klein bottle I hope.”

“A Klein what?”

“Bad math joke. It’s a 3D object that has only one surface. Read some topology back in the day.”

Megan nodded. She thought of an ex of hers who loved math but she wasn’t sure she wanted to bring that up. I do wonder why he wasn’t selected to go on this mission, she thought.

“There’s another reason I wanted to talk to you but I think you might think I’m crazy.”

“I’m crazy enough to have written a book on how to communicate with aliens who don’t use verbal communication. Try me.”

Kara laughed. “You make a fair point there. I can toast to that.”

She raised her mug of fizzy beer and Megan raised her glass of whiskey. After they chugged down a gulp, Kara grimaced. “Definitely you have better taste than me. Where did you get that any way?”

“I brought it with me. Didn’t know what that would have on the ship. Kentucky’s finest. I grew up drinking it.”

“Well, you certainly have foresight. I just assumed that we’ll be too busy to do any serious drinking. If you’re willing to share, after I

finish this crap, maybe you can pour me a bit.”

“Sure, I still have a few more bottles so I don’t mind sharing.”

“Just take it easy and no need to be too cavalier in showing it. You don’t want the whole crew to know you have some good stuff. But let me get back on topic. It’s about the dream that I had last night.”

“Tell me more,” Megan said with eyes widening in curiosity.

“The dream started with a solar eclipse but it was strange since there seemed to be a narrator narrating the sequence of events while it was happening.”

“A narrator?”

“Yes, a female voice that rang in my ears and described what I was seeing. I felt like I was watching a movie and reading a book at the same time. What’s worse is that the perspective kept changing. One moment I was someone on the ground looking up. The next moment I was in the sky in an airplane. I think at another moment I was in space on the moon. It felt disorienting and alien.”

“How long was the dream?”

“It felt like forever but maybe half an hour?”

“Describe it to me in full detail.”

With that prompt, Kara repeated the scenery that played in her dream. When she was done, she waited for the ethnographer to say something.

“I believe this is a form of communication? It may be related to what we’ve experienced so far on this ship.”

“How? It doesn’t make any sense. Through dreams and vague mathematical metaphors?”

“We humans have common languages and cultural repertoires which allow us to have a common platform of using any of the myriad

human tongues to communicate. But imagine if we're trying to communicate with an ant. Ants know how to communicate with each other not through any language that can be written down or spoken but rather through chemicals.

Now, if an intelligent ant is smart enough to be able to learn science and build technology, they must also realize that other lifeforms don't necessarily communicate the same way they do. However, since the gulf between how they communicate, which may be intuitive, is so vastly different from direct singular sentences which humans communicate, what else can they do but translate it into mediums depicting visual and auditory scenes which best approximate how they communicate in their own way? Mathematics is an universal language but it's difficult to convey human emotions without some context around it. Maybe that's why these scenes are so abstract. It's their way to try to convey meaning by providing context around universal truths."

"So you're saying these aliens are like ants?"

"Not at all. I'm using ants as an example since they represent a species which obviously can communicate with each other in very complex ways and maintain cohesion while being completely incomprehensible to us. Any alien species would most likely have a language and communication structure completely alien, pun intended, to us."

"But what about the poem and the book? What does it mean I'm part of a book? I looked up the name of that poem and couldn't find it anywhere."

"Maybe it's a metaphor that we're all part of a bigger story. I'm not sure why a particular reference to an unknown poem is mentioned."

"If we can find the book, maybe things would make more sense."

"Clarity can be hard when trying to communicate with foreign cultures. If you remind me again the name of the poem, I can see what I can do."

"The poem is called *A Day Curated*. I don't know what the book name is."

Megan pursed her lips. "In my view, the book is probably an allegory to the life you or all of us are leading right now. There may not be a title. Interesting word choice though for the title of the book. There may be something more there. Have you had any more dreams or encounters of such words?"

"No, just this one dream. I've been keeping an eye out on any scraps of words or anything describing eclipses but so far nothing has come to my attention."

"I'll keep an eye out too and I'll talk to some others of the crew. Maybe I can put together the pieces of this puzzle. Let me know if you have more dreams."

"I guess that's why they hired you to be on the ship."

"They almost didn't. It was a last minute hire." Megan said simply. She didn't want to go into the details of how that transpired.

A momentary pause as Kara realized that this might be a sensitive question. She cleared her throat to clear the air. "You think this is something I should report to the Captain?"

"You're higher ranked than me. I would think so if we're trying to understand their motivations enough and communicate with them. Maybe you can also inquire if anyone else on this ship is also having similar or other dreams."

"That's not a bad idea. Thank you, Megan."

Kara took one last swig of the cup and got up. "I need to get some rest before my next shift but I'll bring it up next time I see the Captain on deck."

Megan smiled. "Take care of yourself, Kara. I can't say I'm completely right but it's just a hunch and I've been told my hunches have been more right than wrong."

Kara returned her smile and nodded before she walked away. Megan sat there for a few minutes longer gathering her thoughts. She took out her paper-bound notebook and wrote down what just transpired as well as a few of her own theories. This all tied into the larger mystery of the media they've received so far from the alien spacecraft. But what did it all mean? Everyone on board was trying to decipher that but everyone else had other jobs to do to maintain or fly the ship. Her only job was to figure out these meanings. Not all the puzzle pieces are on the board but she's gathering them.

Chapter 5: The Message

Shen woke up to the sound of beating drums. It thudded like the foot stomps of a primeval beast with a simple 1-2-1 rhythm. [More descriptions] He shuddered.

The morning light grazed his eyes, and he half-heartedly opened his eyes in reluctance to meet the morning sun. He had forgotten to close the blinds again and this was what rewarded him. He could feel the fog of sleep lifting from him. With this growing clarity, Shen realized that there were no drumbeats. All that was just the thudding pain from a migraine in his head that seemed to gestate into notable rhythms.

“What time is it?” he muttered to the empty room.

The silence was frightening. He half-turned with a vain hope that she was still beside him. Of course, she wasn't. She was in space on the way to Nexus 1. A one-way suicide trip he had thought and tried to warn her to stay away. Of course, she never listened. The love between two humans though dynamically changing and possibly growing could never measure up a deep love of someone's passion in exploration and intellectual pursuit.

He sighed and voice activated the TV. The news came on. An anchor, no doubt a latest 5th generation AI avatar, spoke resolutely about the on-going resource war in Peru and Bolivia. What was mentioned was the on-going fight between the two countries over resources and control of the mines. More villagers and towns as statistical numbers

were quoted. Some images and videos were shown of the aftermath of the carnage. No illegal weaponry were used with UN Peacekeepers monitoring but conventional approved weaponry were enough these days to cause significant bloodshed.

Shen scoffed. The news these days was worthless. What was not mentioned between the lines was that all the mines on Earth and Luna were running low on resources. Mars alone did not have enough to continue sending the amount necessary to support the 12 trillion people in the Earth-Luna system not even including all the mostly self-sustaining orbital space stations. The technology to mine asteroids have been around for nearly a century now but only now with resource wars happening were visionaries finally getting the funds needed to explore how to do them economically.

Another sign of the short-sightedness of humanity. No one truly cared when the scientists and environmental activist groups warned that the ocean levels were rising every year with increasing temperature until major cities in the powerful nations of the world were starting to be submerged underwater.

Shen mused aloud. "People can barely see past their fingertips. Maybe this is the message that these aliens are coming here to help us with. To learn how to be better stewards of ourselves and this solar system before eventually we reach a crisis that is too late to resolve."

He turned off the TV and glanced at the unfinished book laying on the top of a stack of books. It was a poetry book which he started ten years ago that never transpired into fully published form. He grabbed it and flipped to a random page. The page number read 123. The poem was entitled "Wilderness of My Mind". It was short. He read the next poem called "Orbits".

Shen wondered what happened to his penchant in writing poetry. It seemed to have vanished over the years as morning fog disappeared in the stillness of bright sunlight. He had thought of writing a science

fiction novel that wrapped around the poetry but never took the step down to put pen to paper. He was too afraid of failure and judgment to try. Also, maybe he was too comfortable writing what he was used to despite it offering diminishing returns on meaning for him.

He wondered how authors like Ted Chiang did it. The guy has a computer science degree but ended up writing novellas and short stories that were truly transformative and informative. They were the type of works that got people thinking about what the future could possibly look like or how technology could impact us in a very human sense. The story “Story of Your Life” of learning to communicate with an alien intelligence with the help of a human linguist was in some ways akin to this one he was living in.

Ted Chiang had never written a novel at the time he published that work. Perhaps it’s not the quantity of words but the quality of ideas presented. Shen felt like he had a lot of ideas but most just stayed in his head. If presented in the real world, it would be subjected to scrutiny and either stolen or bashed to pieces. It was safer to stay in his head.

“If I ever do write a novel, I would never be one of those authors who would self-insert themselves into one,” Shen thought.

The irony of this would be surprising to Shen later. He didn’t think any of that would be in this current book, mostly since he thought Apoapsis would have long been completed by then. There was a brief spurt of time at end of January that year where he was writing a lot. Then he lost his steam. Why was the notion that writing would lead him nowhere. He had told a poet friend of his that he stopped writing fiction or poetry since he didn’t feel like it would achieve anything for him professionally. Ironically, this was despite the fact that there were writing workshops, notably one where Ted Chiang participated in, which he felt that he wanted to submit some works and get accepted to as well.

Sometimes, the journey to somewhere starts with prep work. One

might not think one is moving but one actually is! Just that the journey itself might require a chunk of time in prepping to actually get on-board. For instance, getting selected for a writing workshop without paying exorbitant fees meant that he actually had to produce enough works of value to be able to submit. That particular writing workshop required three original works of science fiction short stories. He did not have anything ready to go in the form of short stories for submission but if he had written more beforehand, he would have had a volume to choose from by the time of submission deadline. Since this was once a year, he decided just now that he would like to write more science fiction this year in preparation for that workshop and any other one.

So what changed on this particular day on April 13, 2026? He visited his family living in Atlanta, Georgia in April 2026. Now, neither of his parents would give him any unconventional career advice. This came from grabbing a random book on the bookshelf that was no doubt left by his *meimei* (younger sister) who was a massive bibliophile. The particular book called *The Art of Non-conformity* by Chris Guillebeau informed the reader on stories of people living unconventional lives and discovering their purpose. In there, it mentioned the book *Wishcraft* by Barabara Sher who stated that “Whatever your dreams are, start taking them very, very seriously.”

The author himself stated that at one point he was having a lot of fun and doing many different things, he was not taking his real dreams seriously. This Shen decided was his case as well. If he still dreams of being an established writer of some repute, why would he stop writing?

The idea that other things were more important than pursuing personal dreams was a form of self-delusion. It was holding the self back from the fear of failure or the notion that other things in life was more important. Though coding up a videogame might sound more important, writing prose or poetry was also very essential to his core being.

Hence, this was why two months after the last update on February 14, 2026, he picked up his metaphorical pen and decided to continue writing the story despite his worry that much of it might end up being drivel with a discombobulated plot.

After a short while he stopped and took a break. He went downstairs to get a drink of water from the kitchen. While there, he noticed a picture on the wall. It was one that was given to him by his ex five years ago. *Why do I still have that thing?* He suddenly felt a pang of loneliness and a desire for both emotional and physical intimacy. The right thing to do would be to not dwell and get back to writing. However, the allure of the virtual reality (VR) pod was strong.

This era has far surpassed the Internet capability of the early 2000s in terms of mediavisual production. This was past the stages of the early VR goggles or glasses. Instead of bulky headsets that only provides video and audio and the occasional motion sickness, technology these days in the VR front composed of wearing a haptic suit that covers the entire body with a small amount of space for breathing through the nose. The suit provides full realism in every sense except for taste. That would require a neural implant which Shen was not willing to go there. There are people who were willing to become cyborgs of a sort but he wasn't one of them.

What was even more alluring was the possibility of using AI to create people from images loaded. The sophistication of modern AI was enough for images of people long gone or past their prime to be loaded up and created as hyperrealistic people (with a minimal base set of uploaded personalities). The nerds of high schools these days who would never get the popular girl would only have to scour online social media for enough images to then dump them into an AI avatar generator and create the girlfriend of their dreams. And assuming they have a VR haptic suit which costed about \$20K, they essentially can buy their perfect girlfriend.

People didn't seem to care about the lawsuits that inevitably developed from improper use of others' likeness. It was a nightmare

scenario for a lot of people who had to be careful what they put online lest entire avatars were created of them and used in ways they never intended. What technology has wrought was both a demon and an angel. Shen himself would never do this on anyone who was still alive since that felt like a sense of severe boundary intrusion.

He got into his suit and loaded up a model from the early 21st century. The 3D representation was generated from him loading up hundreds of images of this woman through one of the most sophisticated AI girlfriend generation models in existence. The personality was loaded to be a charming elegant woman. There were some brief conversation but then he was in the action. She looked nothing like his ex which was what he wanted. The part of his mind that stated this was all just an illusion he ignored thoroughly. He also didn't want to think about who this woman was in real life back in the last century.

The moaning and gyration went on for a while. In his suit, he heard the woman cry out his name and he cried out her name as well. He would have to carefully scrub the suit again after this mess.



Figure 3: Stacie

Chapter 19: Revelation

The alarms have gone off and all were quiet. Kara desperately hoped that everyone else were still alive. She still couldn't move though with her leg jammed between two shelves that had fallen. She could only lie there and talk with whatever this alien was.

The hologram of the human child stood in front of her staring at her predicament. He/she/it was holding a wand of some kind. The entity smiled and pointed the device at her. "You are the constant, Kara."

"What do you mean?"

"Think of a set of three coupled differential equations. There is one constant that remains the same in all three differential equations while the other constants are unique to each of the three equations. All three must be solved simultaneously to resolve all of them."

"And you are saying I'm that single constant which is the same for all three worlds?"

"Worlds can suffice with your language but they're far more than that. They're realities which only exist in a bundle. You are that constant which is necessary for the balance of the bundle."

"Why am I unique?"

"What you humans call fate are just constants in mathematical equations to make the worlds function. Certain people are meant to do certain things at certain times. You are special but you are also not."

There are other constants maintaining this balance too, but they have already gone or are not yet here.”

“This problem must be very complicated.”

“Universal balance across multiple shared realities cannot but be complicated. We have simplified the calculations for this particular epoch to only depend on one constant.”

“And that is me? So I am special. What exactly can I do that no one else here can? Everyone here is intelligent and educated and motivated. Some are stronger or smarter than I. What do I have to offer? That’s what I want to know.”

“You are in the ever-present now.”

“You mean I lack the capability to envision the future or reminisce the past? How is that a good thing?”

“Your unique condition in always being in the present emotionally enables you to have the possibility to communicate across shared realities. You just not have yet learned how.”

“Are you here to teach me?”

The entity laughed. It was a light childlike laughter that still seemed too mature coming from this facsimile of a human. The chuckle died away. “You have been learning though you may not know it. Not just your dreams but think of all your interactions on this ship so far. Do you really believe them all to be meaningless coincidences?”

Kara processed the happenings of the past as a list. “I did not see that at the time. So I ask you if this is the end of my lesson.”

“Some say it might be. I say it is only the beginning. Get yourself out of this mess and rescue your crewmates. I will be waiting for you at your next dream.”

The entity started to fade. She had thought that it would have gave her a helping hand in lifting the shelves. Kara frantically cried out. “But wait! I’m still stuck!”

The entity smiled and pointed again at her. Not at her, she realized. She looked down to her right and saw that there was a remote there. It was a remote to move the shelves. She grabbed it and gave a silent prayer that it would work.

She pressed the button. A motor whirred and the shelf trapping her moved a foot letting her leg loose. She quickly removed her leg from the gap and stood up. She looked around. Everything was a mess.

Poetry

The words in Garamond font were clear to all.

Milky Way

The Milky Way is fun-sized as the candy bar says

Swirling in my mouth and swirling overhead

Millionfold stars banded in one luminous light

What a glorious sky to behold brightly tonight

Ancient mythtellers filled with awe knew not what they were seeing

We believers of science today know and yet share the same feeling

Supernova

What is this stellar expansion in my chest masked as nervousness?
Did it exist before these words marked its presence on these pages?
Are these true feelings the yet-to-be lit ending of a lifetime of smoldering fusion? The canvas of my heart cannot be drawn out by traces of lines from the slow drips of a sullen paintbrush To loosen grip of the gravitational pull of unimaginable magnitude, to move atoms freely to a new resonance unbounded by prior frequencies, to create new constellations from the death of old energy states, to reach something

far greater requires a crescendo of change— a sudden supernova for the birth of a nebula with cosmic range

Wilderness of My Mind

In the unbroken wilderness of the jungles of my mind
Lay monsters hiding in underground holes that reside
Fear, resentment and loneliness if I must give them human labels
These nightmarish creatures too real to be merely fables
They pounce and feast upon my psyche when I feel most alone
When I feel my mind splitting and my heart breaking
The harder I run the harder they pursue
Perhaps I've to confront my emotional stew
I'm tired of pieces of me placed in their shopping cart
May a light be shined on these dark corners of my heart

Orbits

This universe is vast everyone likes to say —
but stable periodic orbits are still hard to find
You flew by and were captured in my heart and mind
I thought we'll fly around each other forever
But forces were created strong enough to sever
The attraction not as strong as the repulsion
Your escape velocity was far less than I expected
Our perturbations greater than what you willingly accepted
Perhaps our initial conditions were never properly defined

Propagated states never translated into maneuvers refined
 A trajectory requiring no change being stable was but a fable
 Unaccounted forces and torques over the span of a year
 Set you on a flight path flung far away from here

Moving

Discarded clothes and scrambled emotions on the floor
 Cardboard boxes laden with books and heavy thoughts
 The air permeated with thick fog of memories
 Each item small or large a solid linkage to the past
 Marie Kondo the consultant isn't here
 The magic of tidying up wouldn't help with
 Moving on and moving out
 Not physical objects but tangible memories
 Invisibilities with weights heavier than the physical
 As mental and emotional burdens always are

Doppler Effect and Third Eye

I believe in my third eye
 Linear perspectives play tricks on my usual eyes
 Distant streets always converges to a single point
 An optical illusion my brain is well-adapted to
 However, lately, I've been struck by another illusion
 I've been reading about the Doppler effect

$$f = (c+/-v_r)/(c+/-v_s) * f_0$$

Yesterday, I heard the siren of the fire truck next door
Whine rose in pitch
then fell as its engine sped away
Light from distant stars appear redder
— Hubble says the universe is expanding.
When our spacecraft Odysseus sped away
from terrestrial tracking stations
towards the void that predictably became the moon
I had faith in the physics of measured Doppler frequency shifts
We landed safely.
If physics equals reality and
reality can only be seen by my third eye,
then by the transitive property,
my third eye can see physics.

Physics Reflection on Blue Day

I glance up from my monitor showing atmospheric simulations I see
evening sunlight streaming through smoky sky scattered blue

Perhaps I have played with these models too long They leak into my
interpretation of mundane

Sunlight is composed of photons flung out after nuclear fusion in
the sun Jacchia-Roberts density model is irrelevant to rapidity of
photonic speed Assume refractive index $n = 1.0003$ Light speed re-
duction from vacuum to air by 90 km/s Merely a 3/10,000 reduction
of its total speed

Most brains with eyes don't ponder this sight
The sky is blue with no clouds, so people say
A mundane statement of an accepted ordinary reality

Athena Meeting Artemis

The steely gray winter sky rings a metallic tone
Uniform clouds are but temporary occlusions of space beyond
The heavens above used to be the realm of primal gods.
Our closest neighbor —
the Greeks called her Artemis; the Romans Diana.
The huntress, the moon, the ever-dancing light
The phasing deity that we see but can never touch
Sweat and tears on solid ground here
Fashioned another deity — one of metal, composites and wires
Visible and tangible with innards of invisible software
Athena or affectionately Attie
In a few short months,
this goddess sprung forth from the splitting minds
of human brains
and the aches of human hearts
shall roar above and split the sky.
A week of lonely sojourn in the cosmic pond
and we shall see Attie land to reside on Artemis
a meeting of deities humans have engineered.

Monstrous Poetry

- (1) Look at the birds in the sky! First they caw, then they cry!
Then they fall, then they die!
- (2) Preserved humans arrayed neatly on our shelf in glass jars Soft
bodies with no shells like ours sure marinate well! On harvest
day, we will all eat until our bellies swell!
- (3) Monster hiding quietly under my bed My body feels heavy like
solid lead If I move, it'll know and I'll be dead
- (4) First contact ended in disaster Half the crew gone — brains
eaten To them, the rest are just prey fleeing
- (5) Life wasn't meant to be so sad! Take this happy pill and you'll
be glad! Your pain will be fade and you'll be remade!

Book 73

Sometimes one must

subtract a negative

to add to oneself

The rot inside you

subtracted

becomes

rotten aside

– a separateness

which adds

Light

Nourished by dreams,

Seeds of a new day
Planted the night before
Sprouts forth green hope,
Basked in emerging natural light
If the light is too strong
It'll perish in the heat
If the light is too weak
It'll perish from lack of energy
A delicate balance of the element like
between weight of responsibility and
power of meaning
to evoke a life well-lived
Too much it'll be crushed in stress
Too little it'll die from vapid existence
A life well-lived carries many days
A day well-lived carries many moments
How intense is the light at each moment?

Keyboard

Before finger touches keyboard
There's pen touching paper
They say:
Look for speed and efficiency
Information output in limited time

80+ words per minute. Too slow!

– a standard of the digital age

I say:

What of slow reflection?

No deletion of words but a scratching out leaving behind clear tactile landmarks scenery ...

a baring of the soul

– an outpouring of undiluted unavoidable words,

ideas unbounded by neat lines in Microsoft Word

or standardized image projections in a program?

Absolute no quantifiable standard here

Divinely or earthly – these words on paper just ARE

Breakdown of Comms

Bleached whales

Reside on beaches

Eating nothing

Alive but for just now

King of the ocean

Down there only

On land helpless like a babe

Water provides life

No water no life

Oh! To be such a state!

Forlorn! Dying!

Commensurate what remains
Oh! Great intellect of the sea!
Many come to grasp and point!
Many tries to hear you sing!
Stupid humanoids try but fail
Between land and water,
Sand and ocean,
Human and you,
Invisible boundary –
breakdown of comms

Borders of the Mind

Borders of the mind
Are even more so than
The territorial edges of nations
Who makes and gives out these passports?
I asked the HR lead at work
“Do you write poetry?”
In a terse email reply, she without hesitation replied:
“I’m a working professional. I’ll write when I’m retired.”
I thought of my ma; she said she reach much and wrote much when
younger
I’ve never seen her words (except for her red marks editing my essays
in childhood)
When asked, she without hesitation replied:

“I’ll write when I’m retired.”

Like different colors across invisible lines, the line
between personal & professional,
analytical & creative,
logical & emotional,
many exist proud of the divisions in the mind
No entry on arrival there.

Faith

Am I truly loved?
When I dream of
You,
Do I exist in the dreams of
You?
You are everything and everywhere
So explain all this pain and emptiness
Inside my heart in the dark stillness of the night
Under this serene moonlit sky
What I feel within
If I call out for
You
If I scream for
You
Can the words really reach

You?

Whose faith is stronger?

Yours in mine?

Mine in Yours?

Emptiness

An emptiness

A space

A feeling of nullity

Entrapped in body and mind

Not an escape but a prison

Feeling of release – itself a delusion

Just a wrapping of further chains – lies beget lies

All wound together to wound more

Wound the heart; constrain the spirit

Life is hard, stressful, sad, terrifying, depressing, etc.

But is this altered state liberation?

It is a false shell – the hollowness only grows

The prison remains.

Emotions

New and same versions of self

Conjoined but disjointed

Cobbling together driftwood

- P i e c e s of the past

I feel lost for words (but I need them)

I can tell you fear, stress, pain, excitement, happiness, loss, and
ultimately a form of ecstasy

divinely inspired or chemically induced

at that moment of launch all seems jumbled within

emotions are cosmic sisters by karmic design

one begets another and then another –

a decision tree with spiraling arms

Who can say why I feel like painfully crying a moment ago

but now is filled with silent serene joy

Breath one

Breath two

Breath three

What's next?

More sadness or more joy?

Something in between?

Sometimes I see nothing but a faceless blackness

In that nothingness of a second,

I feel years pass; time flies

walking through graveyards of memories

I taste only decayed ashes

of time not feeling –

an utter numbness or lack of registration

the void devoid of memorable feelings

is the true cosmic horror
home is where the heart is
a warm glow like sunset
or campfires surrounded by bewitching stories told
or the amber glow of autumn grain fields
words form the walls preserving my past

- ensuring I feel ALL

Console

Uncommon sight – another long day
Its ending only to reveal more
Awkward postures; longer nights
Warm bodies under fluorescent lights
States of heads bound in reverie
Circulating voices for us to hear and see
Under quiet glows
Of machines lined up in rows
Some speak with firm authority
Some speak with quiet grace
Some speak with frantic urgency
Some speak with a look not a word
Mental activity in flight,
Physical activity grounded,
Are our souls with our bodies or our minds?

Distressed Highway

I-45 may be littered with the debris from the ever moving city
Broken glass, old nails, discarded wood, trash of all varieties
Yesterday, plastic flew off someone's truck bed and assaulted all the
cars behind it.

As a kid, I recall playing racing games where obstacles don't kill you
ever

Real life au contraire

If the highway traffic is semblant of passage of life, even more so

Broken promises of yesterday and discarded love

Lay in gaping manholes covering wide swaths of my road

Littered with the cans filled with anxieties and addictions

I've gotten better at driving and the cleanup crew has filled up some
of those holes and removed some of these cans

Still, much work remains...

I just keep on trucking, occasionally swerving,

Sometimes I succeed; other times I get dented

Never do I stop moving

Words

Pitch black, pure silence

No sight, no sound

Closed eyes

Used to yield

Inner sight

Strange worlds divorced from reality
Imagination-infused fizzling concoctions
Sour-blue razz hedonisms
Strawberry sweet love
Coffee-tinged hate
Bitter aftertaste of betrayal
Sweet foretaste of poetic justice
So why now this utter blandness?
What happened to my daydreams carrying me to Shangri-La?
What happened to the worlds my brain creates incessantly?
Perhaps an overdose of external stimuli
From the doings and goings of others
Have left my brain to sit still in idleness
Leaving only gaping silences – like the long pauses
Utterings from one who has forgotten how to speak
There is no panacea for a mental blockade
There is no elixir of eternal creativity
But I must try for imagination to me
Is equivalent to life
Time to re-stitch my brain and eject what is not needed
Turn off my TV, computer, phone
Just sit here and read a paper book
Preferably in a language not English

Butterflies

Translation:

Heavy mountain after mountain

Light butterfly takes flight

Carrying meaning crossing ground

Flying towards blue-green sky

Where the mountain meets sky

Where the cool air is rarefied

Here in the lonely apex of frost

Blue lapis butterfly flies seemingly lost

Not a mirage but one of intense reality

Sunlight glinting bright and true

She flutters her gossamer wings

Departing for warmer skies as she sings

BLUE

U X

T I

T THICK

E S A

R SOL I D

FLIES C A E

L A Z S

YESTERDAY E

E

R

TERRAIN

Climb to Summit at Lost Maples

Breath after breath

Step after step

Rock after rock

Tree after tree

Afternoon wanes

But Sun still shines

One more step

Zero thoughts

At last: the summit

Breathe and look up

Only sky and wind
Breathe and look down
Only trees and water

Existence is Not an Equation

Do a job long enough and the mysteries of life become filtered through
lens carved by repeated mental grooves,

I like to see my journey akin to a vehicle flying in outer space,

Existence known just a network of neurons firing continuously inter-
preting sensations taken by organic receivers,

A trajectory of my life designed to follow an idealized path optimized
for a particular objective

But now that I know my life trajectory cannot be optimized.

Though I do draw out grand plans,

perturbations from people, myriad forces, and the hand of God

introduces major deviations from nominal with no predicted 3-sigma
covariance,

There is no optimizing life

There is only living it

Wishing for a Storm

All day a sterile sunshine

The strongest light that streams

This giant flat pancake of a sky

Oven-baked, sweltering,

Hazy moist steaming air

Perpetual enviro of a coastal city
Where is the wind?
I lay here somnambulant
Clear blue skies tire me
I long for a summer storm
Grey to brown to a medium even more richly dark
Perhaps a chocolate black I can smell, taste, and feel
Crisp cool wind hammering my skin
Accompanied by the percussion of thundering claps
The beginning of another apocalypse
a summer hurricane pouring down a flood
or just the passing of another summer storm
The depth of the storm does not matter
the feeling of a need for change is all there is

June

Spring forsaken by the passage of Earth More turns of the terrestrial
axis Shadows that were, are lessened The day is objectively longer –
subjectively brighter this summer
I feel carried in the shadow that remains like broken pieces wrapped
within a neat package stuffed in a plane still shaking after a storm
Much of what I want to say gleams out of reach like the silvery mirage
floating on a road baked by the summer sun
Maybe my role is to listen Meditate in a room of silence Hear the
beating of my heavy chest Its voice clear at last

Autopilot

There is a door to
the darkness, you get used to it.
You get used to everything:
the warm humid summer air
the roads always under
permanent construction, never finished
Like what life is about?
I sit on the bridge above I-59
imagine the comings and goings of
metal canisters moving at the velocity
of snails; rush hour traffic
A joke – rushing at the pace of crawling
The sky is still bright and the stars
have yet to glow
Everything not yet smeared in inky black
These people down there – what are
the states of their inner selves?
Bright or fading like a coming night?
Each vessel is yet to be automated
but who says the driver isn't automated
– moving through the mechanical
motions of life (a spiritual void; a darkness of its own)
commute, work, commute, eat, relax,

sleep, repeat –

even social fun reduced to a

common banality of superficial exchanges

- Did you watch the game last night?
- What do you think of this show?
- How are the kids?
- What else do you get to complain about now?
- How was your vacation?

I like to retreat. Stare at the mirror

reflection of my God-given hands.

I wave. The figure waves back.

I stare in wonder.

To know myself. To feel. To control my body.

What wonder!

Summer Zephyr

The summer zephyr does not flow here

A humidity akin to a rain forest

but with a scorching sun parching my soul and bone

I long for a breath of fresh air

Winter calm in snow under mistletoe

If I close my eyes, I can taste the sour grapes

of yesterday's seasonal cheer

If I close my eyes, I can see the swirling majesty

of the Milky Way imprinted on a dark cool midnight sky
I open my eyes and I only feel a suffocating heat
Yet, there's something to be said about
the endless blue summer sky and the chirping of cicadas
bringing back memories of halcyon days of childhood
long bike rides followed by icy lemonade
fresh adventures and memories yet to be made

Camera Calibration

Our ancestors huddled around campfires gazed above
Formulating patterns from randomized celestial dots
Mythological heroes, monstrous beasts, etc.
Stories derived from a tapestry of disconnected lights
Today we of a sounder pragmatic mind
of a scientific bent instead of a mythological kind
with inorganic electronic instruments pointed at the sky
these same stars repurposed for a different design
To gaze in a different bandwidth capturing the same light
To fix hot pixels and possibly correct a camera matrix
To correct distortions and remove any other wrong trace
As the spacecraft hurtles towards the moon on this new race

Shoes

No shoes fit my feet
Shoes that snugly fit me

may be hanging above among stars
When I look at night,
I see no shoe-shaped constellation
I am always surprised when
some fall from the skies
alighting at the dusty dishevelled stacks at
local Goodwill or Plato's Closet
Others drop ignobly on dry glass –
Never to be scooped up with no matching pair
But no shoe seems to be able to comfortably fit my sole
or maybe each is just too tight to fit my expanding soul
mine is best carried on my feet on their soles
walking across all the ground a large soul traverses

Dance Poem 1

I step outside of the dance to observe
The flow that goes through the myriad souls
Vibrating, gyrating, twisting
On a dark floor – motions minute and grand
Bodies lit not only by the rainbow
and string lights above
But more so by the
effervescent lights of human souls
Shining within – expressed

as movement externally
Static words on lined pages can capture only a fragment
To truly know what it feels
To truly see the lights within
To truly feel the meaning beneath movement
Requires a plunge into the self through the dance
My incessant urge to record and think
Stops for the moment here
As I return to stepping
into the music and motions

Marie Kondo's Goodwill

Written on a day where I donated some items to Goodwill.

Marie Kondo's book may be no more
(I gave it to a friend not a store)
but I following her good advice took
some of my discarded past for more joy
and gave them to those who can use it
in the present
I shall name them:

- Clothes that no longer tell the story of who I now am (rather, they in their banal polo stripes and mundane logos misrepresent me as a corporate icon)
- Costumes from an ex – bright colors where she wore to pretend to be someone who she's not (when she left with her betrayal she left those too for me to pick up)

- Old computer bag with plum blossoms which I tried to salvage
but sadly broken under the weight of the passage of time and
books carried too often

These I gave in ignoble piles heaped up

On a larger pile of good will –

May they find new homes freed from my memories.

Dance Poem 2

The words are overpowering

New worlds built within the framework of language

Motions ranging from wild gesticulations

of arms waving 180 degrees per second

and feet leaping into the sky – just a foot

but enough joy atomized

into a minuscule space

Others scarcely 1 degree per second moving calmly

as if taking a leisurely albeit slightly eccentric stroll

through the park

In an artificial field of a temporary haven of

motions left to free choice,

I'm frequently tempted to take the role of the observer

I see everyone in their primal forms in a natural habitat

— some with primal screams.

But is it my natural habitat?

Perhaps the unrestrained flight

of motions still at times frighten me –
I like to fly but I'm bound by gravity:
physically so but more so emotionally
I am comforted by the cocoon of words
written strunged together while sitting still on the sidelines
Overanalyzing brain?

A Day Curated

On a day with no concrete plans
Infinity stretches in front of me
If I'm not careful, the
Infinite can converge towards zero
(There's an allure to hiding from the world.)
Form can be anything
But it's pure chaos without structure
Just like the Earth must rotate and revolve,
So too my life cannot be a frozen state in spacetime,
But if there's no laws of physics curated
Coincidentally or by providence to have
an appropriate rotational rate for day and night
to coexist in life-affirming quantities,
an appropriate average distance from the sun
to not boil or freeze this planet,
an appropriate eccentricity to the orbit

and a slight tilt to the axis of rotation to have reasonable seasons,
life without physical curation would be dead.

I ask myself a simple but hard question:

in the name of freedom, I can do anything I want

but to offer my existence greater meaning,

to fully enter my essential self,

to build towards the future knowing the past,

where do I fling myself to today in a

state of change – bounded to affirm joy, unbounded to affirm freedom

Sitting in Front on Floor of Inprint

The floor in front of the door at Inprint is a good place to sit

A halfway point to hear the words from around the corner

But not to see the speaker of those words

Peculiarities of physics

Sound waves can diffract around corners

Visible light can diffract too but

its high energy has a downside

Visible light 380 to 750 nanometers versus

Sound waves 17 m to 17 mm for the audible range

Lends the bending around corners

With massive obstacles on the order of meters impossible

More specifically, let's use the equation $\sin(\theta) = \lambda / W$

where θ is angle of diffraction, λ is wavelength and W is obstacle length

You do the math

Energy in its myriad forms and manners of transfer intrigue me

These meandering words led me here

A mundane experience such as that of sitting uncomfortably on the floor

Turned into an observation of the extraordinary:

The physics of energy happening in all mundane experiences

– whether I am comfortable or not.

Transparency still abounds and clarity still exists

Spilled water on words of my spiral notebook

blurs the multitude of introspection

ranging from mundane records of foods eaten this week

to planetary-scale existential thoughts –

what I feel in a cyclic fashion is a heavy dark void with a gravity

I find near impossible to escape

I do not mean that I want to end myself though in years past, the near-complete lack of self-acceptance has led me down dark mental paths

No, this massive emotional gravity stems not from a mass the size of a black hole or even a neutron star

I've lived life through several stages of evolution and grown in awareness

not the point of being clairvoyant

but no longer harbouring the twin masses of shame and guilt

The latest source of emotional gravity mostly stems from fear and anxiety

Dual types of massive particles which in multitudes meld into a spherical dark sun providing the opposite of illumination

The raw material's existence isn't a mystery to me

Childhood traumas cast long shadows in presence of any light

The beautification starts from the present

I drink the water of connection through these words given to the world

Overcoming the past to live in the present to build the future

Fire

I sit and observe from a vantage point previously unexperienced

Illuminated by the central pit of live flames burning dry dead wood

Flying embers of fire flakes

and translucent ash

Drift lazily upwards into

the infinity of space

Too close and the flame

with its dominating presence

covers all within sight

Distance provides a perspective –

possibly an optical illusion

but to my gaze a direct path

to the constellation Cassiopeia

Screaming at Work

Unbridled emotions hard to capture in span of quarter hour

... so my head goes to today

This morning while writing code

I felt a scream inside grow louder

Not sure if I was feeling quite well,

didn't have time to observe to reveal

I believe in happiness tinged with stress

Logic and rationality are the dual invisible

cords in an engineering company

Spaceflight may be inspiring but

my compatriots are mainly of cerebral quantity

Confinement of my soul with a desire for joyous release

to gyrate and grunt from a primal self

sing and bellow unbridled emotions

No, none of that allowed here I fear –

I turned up the music even louder,

felt the beats thundering in my ears,

pounded my plastic keyboard with renewed vigor,

started at the tiny 12-font lines on the dual screens,

smelled the scentless fluorescent-lit air,

tasted the latest sip of cooling green tea

balanced on my feet firmly grounded to the floor

still standing and working.

Perception on Love #1

A lot of my little fucks are turning into a big one

Fuck my sense of decency and propriety

Nice poems or words in general written by my calm hand

Must be scrubbed clean of f-bombs and s-dynamites

Sometimes I'm fucking tired of this shitty self-censure

I don't want to appear unrefined so I choose

To hide these vulgar words and vulgar ideas

But how vulgar is it really to express rawness?

I painted my chair a year ago –

a nice little fuck you to someone who I had once loved

She had loved its pure white color and its imitation Parisian style

I never liked inauthenticity; if it's not French it shouldn't pretend to be

I painted these words on the back –

Purity is overrated. This chair can be used for sitting or fucking.

Done the former plenty of times; haven't yet tried the latter but I'll be curious if that little wooden thing can hold two people's weight.

My mind can be beautifully pure and still have hedonistic desires

I know this when I feel infuriating annoyance at a Christian friend who said to me recently that he's marrying a girl he dated for 14 months – a paltry amount of time in my perspective

This is his first relationship and he admitted he never had sex; he doesn't even sleep in the same bed as she this entire time and appeared bashful even stating that he has kissed her

I wish them the best but since I'm a rather jaded soul in some respects
I don't have much faith in a purity like this

Love in what appears to be its purest form can seem beautiful but
there's great risk in giving everything without knowing anything

Knowing nothing about the importance of passion in a relationship

Knowing nothing on what pleasures of the flesh one loves, and to
what extent one's partner is able or willing to provide

Knowing nothing on what the partner desires in bed and what one
is able or willing to do

What about me? When I choose to love, I am swept over by passion

I have made love with a handful (nothing I want to openly flaunt
since quantity means nothing compared to quality)

Memorable ones are in the woods, in cars (try not to get caught adds
to the sexual thrill), on rooftops, in strangers' beds, etc.

To my Christian friend, if he's the judgmental type, I must be this
hedonistic animal given in to desire

Truth be told, I do tend to have emotions overwhelm me

Perhaps feelings of the moment aren't really lasting, and physical
intimacy may be a mistake, some may argue.

I do not agree. To me, union of spirit to its fullest degree with
certainty brings with it a union of the mind and body

Love shouldn't be segregated from pleasure, and neither are the most
apparent in the act... rather, it's the basking in the afterglow of
just laying or sitting there carrying intimate conversation with light
touches and sometimes enraptured cuddling

The sensations in life are meant to be fully experienced if the rule of
authenticity and respect is present. In other words, be truthful and
be kind. There can be beauty and love to the fullest extent inside or
outside the societal construct of marriage. Calling it a construct may

anger some including this friend but the modern world (or maybe for all human history) has layered rules legal and financial upon that. Its true divine meaning has long lost its importance in light of all this.

I want to not to live in a world bounded by constructs which can bring damage to my emotional and spiritual state. In every society, the original intentions are to offer stability and propriety to humans that cannot be left to chaos and moral decay. For the aim of stability and morality, billions mechanically follow the motions without ever questioning. A lifetime of resigned unhappiness like my parents or a cascade of broken hearts. The rainbow array of human experiences demand that some rules are best left ignored or forgotten.

Shen is a Whore

I am a whore

for words and for one who speaks words

I love the way letters are arranged

sequentially in a seemingly nonsensical

fashion and form meaning from nothing

I must be a maximalist

I'm a whore who hoards

I love hearing more when less can be said

when the more feels so much more

I could say a rhizome is a continuously growing horizontal underground stem which a plant's roots and shoots sprout OR I could quote a section of page 5 of A Thousand Plateaus:

The multiple must be made, not by always adding a higher dimension, but rather in the simplest of ways, by dint of sobriety, with the number of dimensions one already has available – always $n-1$ (the

only way the one belongs to the multiple: always subtracted). Subtract the unique from the multiplicity to be constituted; write at $n-1$ dimensions. A system of this kind could be called a rhizome.

The words continue but I pause in quoting. Not everyone needs to be a French philosopher or a psychoanalyst. No, you don't have to be one of renowned refinedness. I don't need you to write me an essay or a book on grand philosophical ideas. Even a modicum of simplicity in saying "I love you" can be maximized into a poem or maybe just a well-written sentence:

I long and ache for our voluminous interactions of delights ranging from the mundane to the sublime leading inexorably to a mutualistic growth of souls and a tender warmth we give each other's hearts.

Touching the Flame

our ability and our attempt to perceive & understand
humans emotions and intentions
needing to interpret all words and symbols
perhaps the embodiment of all relationships
are akin to observing distant stars
we can learn to accept every disembodied light
too many around us to recognize
bright and cast afar across a vacuum
in a variegated spectrum of waves
sometimes interpreted as particles
explaining who they are
we can't even imagine
the burning of countless nuclear fires

the blast furnace of inhuman flames
crossing the icy chill of space
limitless yet bounded by finite speed
eons later, these light
pronounce shadows on all solid things
waiting to be touched and grasped
as we try to comprehend them
maybe we may never really know
but that doesn't mean it's not worth it to try

A Poem for Gina

words are like clothing that can hopefully
adorn a soul of great myriad beauty like yours
clothing which doesn't deteriorate
but only enhance and shine brighter with
with each revolution of earth
around the primal fire of the sun
so too have you grown in your revolutions
small and large
your creative spirit lingers ever there, while
internally maturing in patience, kindness, and love
where once you followed spontaneous impulses,
now more than ever reason helps guide your path,
thoughts many once unclear have been dusted away

externally, you've seen your children become adults,
further grandchildren germinate and grow,
and the children in schools you teach and nurture,
all of them akin to plants whose you seeded in your garden
except born from human flesh
with a soul you help shape to shine as brightly as yours
whether by fortune or fate,
to be all brought together on another December day
the planet this season in the evening may be dark outside
but a loving family and friends create its own light

Silence of the Night

Do I write to fill up a blank space?

Do I speak to fill up a sudden silence?

I recall as a child

the stillness of the book on the desk

before I opened its pages and devoured them

the silence of the moon

amidst the quiet of the night distant from gaze of sun

the prayer of the heart

spoken to no one but my own soul

And there is the silence of this night

when my pen put down these words

a rich quietness

free from the tumbling blocks of the day

Maybe this is why I love the night

not for the nightlife as most picture it

but like snow falling on the roofs darkened

after sunset,

a life renewed only in the silence

of thoughts and words

and prior to that

Before I wrote a single word

-- nothing at all

blank space and zero words

Sequence

People can be described mathematically

Sequence of numbers with a pattern

Some follow a fairly linear progression

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

Others build up on their experiences from the past

though starting at 0 they slowly grow

0 1 1 2 3 5 8 13 21 34 55 89

Others are blessed to exponentially expand

as if they can barely contain their own power

1 2 4 8 16 32 64 128 256 512 1024

but they're also the ones likely to have early termination

Few humans know what to do with an oversurge

of fame or power

Some take it the other direction

a negative compression

1 $\frac{1}{2}$ $\frac{1}{4}$ $\frac{1}{8}$ $\frac{1}{16}$ $\frac{1}{32}$ $\frac{1}{64}$ $\frac{1}{128}$ $\frac{1}{256}$ $\frac{1}{512}$ $\frac{1}{1024}$

though they still somehow remain positive

I'm more familiar with another sequence

where negativity frequently creeps in and the odd 0

1 -1/2 1/6 0 -1/30 0 1/42 0 -1/30 0 5/66

Bernoulli numbers are good representations

of not just being the first computer generated sequence

or the Taylor series expansion of

hyperbolic tangent functions -

they're abstract representations of

my ever-fluctuating emotional state

seemingly without reason but

following a pattern precisely defined by

$B_n = 1 - k = 0, n = 1, n_k B_{n-k} = n+1$

The Dog

the hollow roots of this slothful

ecstasy surely will lose their

form once the real wind gusts

the shallow pond of deceit and
cowardice surely cannot hide
the sins committed once again

the forlorn dog cannot view the
masters face without grimacing

the dog knows him too well

how the dog knows more than the
master who only carries an unbidden smile
they say dogs can view the soft soul
beneath the hard skin
the hard skin with creased shiny smiles
and empty long laughs and words
carried on plates of platitudes
but no plate of anything unreal can feed the dog
a grimace ... a growl ... a whimper ...

Delusions of Gods and Time

These gods old and new living in the forests of our minds

We make and are a mockery of gods

Small-minded creatures beget small-minded gods

Death reduced to Hades, Love reduced to Aphrodite,

War reduced to Ares, Birth reduced to Eileithyia,

Wisdom reduced to Athena, Sea reduced to Poseidon

Those who worship the gods go the gods

Worshipped and worshipers filled with temperamental temperaments

Loving & kind and in a clash of thunder,

hateful & harsh and in another,

back again.

To save the life of one and condemn entire nations to ruin...

ultimately all fickle whims are based in time

All suffer under delusion from birth

with **unidirectional time the arbiter**

But worship must be unified to intellectual inquiry

No known physical laws microscopically require a temporal direction

Time is an evolution no longer valid in quantum gravity

In the field equation $\hat{H}(\Psi)|\Psi=0$

$\hat{H}$ -hat acting on ket psi equals zero

where

$\hat{H}(\Psi)$ is the Hamiltonian constraint and $|\Psi$ is universal wave-function

Ill-defined in the general case,

Wheeler and DeWitt lit the fire...
can we set the forest ablaze?

Brink of Life

Thoughts unspoken in the shallow
crevices of my brain
My faith isn't whole, it's a hole
The steps of initial calmness — an
utter joy of new faith
To go from depth of death to brink of life
given music to my ears more beautiful
than what I had played
But there are dark tunnels in my brain
an eternal anxiety and fear that hole
grew like a gnawing worm through
a solid apple
This bitterness I taste in my mouth
This ground is dark and dreary
If I am to truly believe the word of one
who rules over death, am I naïve or
insane? I must look. I mustn't look.
Do I believe the chaos rampaging in my head?
Do I trust the words of a fickle god?

Corpse of Life

Wood, steel, glass, gold

The myriad variety of materials constructed eons ago or just today

We continue this unnatural ritual

Mummified in sarcophagus

Cindered in urns

Decomposed in coffins

The sun is anathema to our remains

The dead like vampires cannot bear the light

Or

Is it that we of the living cannot bear to be reminded of our fates

We must try to lock death away in containers;

We think death should not see life...

But imagine your body

Feeding back to life

Lying on warm summer grass –

Imagine the sunlight blessing your remains as you nourish the soil

A new ritual

Performed by death for life

